



MAYAN numbers

Native Americans also discovered farming and invented ways of writing numbers. The Mayans had a number system even better than that of the Egyptians. They kept perfect track of the date and calculated that a year is 365.242 days long. They counted in twenties, perhaps using toes as well as fingers. Their numbers look like beans, sticks, and shells – objects they may once have used like an abacus.

1 was



2 was



3 was



4 was



5 was



The symbols for 1–4 looked like cocoa beans or pebbles. The symbol for 5 looked like a stick.

The sticks and beans were piled up in groups to make numbers up to 20, so 18 would be:



ROMAN numbers

Roman numbers spread across Europe during the Roman empire. The Romans counted in tens and used letters as numerals. For Europeans, this was the main way of writing numbers for 2000 years. We still see Roman numbers today in clocks, the names of royalty (like Queen Elizabeth II), and books with paragraphs numbered (i), (ii), and (iii).

Like most counting systems, Roman numbers start off as a tally:

1 is I **2 is** II **3 is** III

Different letters are then used for bigger numerals:

V	X	L	C	D	M
5	10	50	100	500	1000

